On-site Assignment and Signals Handbook

Design an assignment from the role, say what a strong response contains, and decide the signals you will look for before you meet anyone.

How to use it. Complete sections 2 to 4 for each role you hire, with the hiring manager and one future teammate. Reuse the structure, not the brief.

1. What a good on-site assignment promises

- [ ] The time it takes is stated up front, and it happens in one sitting, on site
- [ ] The problem is shaped like the real job, and no company secrets or free work are being collected
- [ ] The candidate can ask questions and talk to people on the team while they work
- [ ] The candidate owns their work, and it is used only for evaluation
- [ ] Everyone applying for the same role gets the same brief and the same criteria
- [ ] Every candidate gets a reply, and feedback if policy allows

2. Define the challenge from the job role

The core problem this role will own
From the Role Definition Worksheet. What will this person be responsible for solving?

The assignment problem statement
Context, who it is for, the constraint, and what is out of scope. Short enough to read in two minutes.

What the candidate is given and who they can ask
Materials, access to a product manager or engineer, tools, a quiet space

Time and format
Length of the session, how it ends, how long they present

3. Define the deliverable criteria

Derive these from the problem statement and the role. Write what a strong response contains, and also what you do not need, so nobody is marked down for skipping it.

DELIVERABLE	WHY THIS ROLE NEEDS IT	WHAT STRONG LOOKS LIKE	NOT NEEDED
Problem framing			
Approach and flow			
Decisions and trade-offs			
Communication and walk-through			
Response to critique			

4. Define the signals for the role

A signal is something you can observe that predicts success in this job. Name it, say how it shows up in the room, and decide how you will probe it.

ROLE	SIGNAL	HOW IT SHOWS UP IN THE ROOM	HOW WE PROBE IT
Product designer	Frames the problem before solving it	Asks about users and constraints first, restates the problem in their own words	Change a constraint halfway and watch how they adapt
Researcher	Chooses the method for the question	Explains why this method, what it cannot tell us, and what they would do next	Ask what they would do with half the time
Design systems designer	Thinks in reuse and rules	Finds the pattern behind the screens, defines when not to reuse it	Hand them an edge case the system does not cover
Design lead or manager	Raises the people around them	Draws out the team in the room, handles disagreement openly	Ask how they would give feedback on this very work

5. Run the session

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENS	WHO IS THERE
Before		
Start		
During		
Walk-through		
Close		

6. Record what you saw

SIGNAL	WHAT I SAW OR HEARD	RATING 1 TO 4

What I would want to explore further, and what I would tell the candidate